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RACE ENDS HERE

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[...]

THIS BRIEF AND HIGHLY POLEMICAL presentation might have been more appropriately entitled 'Now you see it, now you don't'. It seeks to question how we see 'race', how the signs and symbols of racial difference become apparent to our senses. It does not admit the integrity of any avowedly natural perceptual scheme. It does not concede the idea of a way of seeing race that remains unmediated by technical and social processes, for there is no raw perception dwelling in the body. The human sensorium has had to be educated. When it comes to the visualization of 'race' a great deal of fine tuning has been required. Underpinning my argument is a desire to link the historical and critical study of raciologies and 'racial' metaphysics to the new histories of visuality and perception that are being produced, to connect it with some timely critiques of absolute identity and their associated genealogies of subjectivity and, above all, to link it to an understanding of the technoscientific means that have fostered and mediated particular relations with our race-coded selves in the modern past. [...]

The history of racism is a narrative in which the congruency of micro- and macrocosm has been disrupted at the point of their analogical intersection: the human body. Biology was only one of many possible ways of addressing this relationship with ourselves. Though it preceded the distinctive quality of sociality we distinguish as modern, the order of active differentiation that gets called 'race' may be modernity's most pernicious signature. It articulated reason and unreason. It knitted together science and superstition. Raciology required that enlightenment and myth be intertwined. Indeed, 'race' and nationality supplied the logic and mechanism of their interconnections. The specious ontologies of 'race' are anything but spontaneous and natural. They should be awarded no immunity from prosecution amidst the reveries of reflexivity and the comfortable forms of inertia induced by capitulation to the lazy essentialisms from which post-modern sages inform us we cannot escape. To cut a long story short. We could begin again by asking what that trope 'race' lodged in the body might mean in the age defined by globalization and digital technologies on the one hand and molecular biology on the other?

Today, we have been productively estranged from the anatomical scale defined at the end of the eighteenth century when natural history gave way initially to biology. We are more sceptical than ever about the status of visible differences in relation to the unseen. On what scale is human sameness, human diversity now to be calibrated? Can a different sense of scale and scaling combine with a new sense of illumination to form a counterweight to the appeal of absolute particularity celebrated under the sign of 'race'? Can a sense of the arbitrariness of scale help to answer the seductions of self and kind projected on to the surface of the body but stubbornly repudiated inside it by the proliferation of invisible differences that produce catastrophic consequences where people are not what they seem to be? In the instability of scale that characterizes our episteme, how is racialized and racializing identity to be imagined when we know that it has already been imaged? Is there still a place for 'race' when human life and human difference are contemplated on a restlessly sliding scale?

The modern idea of race operated within the strictest of perceptual limits. The shift from natural history to biology prompted changes in the modes and meanings of the visual and the visible. When it appeared to make sense of life and nature biology promoted specific modes of communication and representation that, on the basis of particular technologies, both created and marked out a novel relationship between text and image. Life, fractured along raciological lines, was visualized, imaged in novel and striking ways. Race was intrinsic to this change. Later, the consolidation of physiology as a distinct branch of medical knowledge would be accompanied by a refinement in the technical and instrumental basis of bio-representation. Here, too, 'race' was a primary object of knowledge and power.

For simplicity's sake, let's call that distinctive ratio, the scale of comparative or Euclidean anatomy. The idea of 'race' leaked out of the lofty confines where what Foucault calls the 'chemical gaze' was most fully developed. But it always worked best in the setting provided by those distinctive ways of looking, enumerating, measuring, dissecting and evaluating. More than this, the idea of 'race' defined and consolidated typologies that could not be dissociated from their very specific representational technology and its perceptual and cognitive regimes. The truths of race were produced 'performatively' from the hat that biological science provided, like so many startled rabbits in front of a noisy, eager, imperial crowd. 'Race' became an important means to link metaphysics and technology; it made sense readily within these unprecedented historical conditions.

Our situation is different. The call of racial being has been weakened by a different technological and communicative revolution, by the idea that the body is nothing more than an incidental moment in the transmission of code and information, by its openness to the new imaging technologies, and by the loss of mortality as a horizon against which life is to be lived. Blackness can now signify vital prestige rather than abjection in a global info-tainment telesector, where the residues of slave societies and the parochial traces of American racial conflict must yield to different imperatives deriving from the planetarization of profit and the cultivation of new markets far from the memory of bondage. They had Sartje Baartman, we have a *pas de deux* between the super-human, godly Michael Jordan and Bugs Bunny, the *reductio ad absurdum* of hybridized African trixter tale-telling. Can we agree that the eighteenth-century perceptual regimes that gave us 'race' have been superseded along with their epistemological and metaphysical pretensions?

The story of how the one-to-one scale of comparative anatomy and its world of natural light were recontextualized by the advent of the microscopic and the artificial has

been addressed by several historians and need not be outlined in detail here. Rather, I would like to leapfrog over the exemplary image of the cinematographically minded physician Robert Lincoln Watkins peering at tainted blood through his 'micro-motoscope' and turn instead towards the more recent situation in which the microscopic has given way to the molecular. This development means that much of the contemporary discourse producing 'races' and racial consciousness can be identified as an anachronistic and even vestigial phenomenon. Where screens rather than lenses and mirrors mediate the pursuit of bodily truths, 'race' might best be approached as an after-image – a lingering symptom of looking too intently or too casually into the damaging glare emanating from colonial conflicts at home and abroad.

On the journey away from modernity's inaugural catastrophes in the new world, raciological ways of organizing and classifying the world have retained that special baggage of perspectival inclinations, perceptual habits and scalar assumptions. Their anthropologies depended and still depend upon observations that cannot be wholly disassociated from the technological means that have both fostered and mediated them. This was where the anatomical scale was first broken. Optical microscopes transformed what could be seen but the new technologies of seeing on ever smaller and smaller scales moved the threshold of visibility and has contributed to an enhanced sense of the power of the unseen and the unseeable. The eugenic ravings of Francis Crick, the Nobel prize winning co-discoverer of DNA, demonstrate exactly how the fateful change of scale involved in the founding of molecular biology and the redefinition of life in terms of information, messages and code was recognized as having cataclysmic moral and political consequences. Rubble from the broken palace of bio-politics provided the foundations for what might now be called 'nanopolitics'.

Let me be blunt: scientific and biological, historical and cultural, rational and irrational, skin, bone and even blood are no longer primary referents of racial discourse. If the modern episteme was constituted through processes that forsook the integrity of the whole body and moved inside the skin to enumerate organs and describe their functional relationship to an organic totality, the situation today is different. The same 'inward' direction has been maintained and the momentum increased in ways that compound the difficulties involved in separating inside from outside. The aspiration to perceive and explain through recourse to the power of the minute, the microscopic and now the molecular, has been consolidated. In a space beyond and below that of comparative anatomy, the whole integral body and its obvious, functional components no longer delimit the scale upon which assessments of the unity and variation of the species are to be made. The naked eye was long ago recognized as insufficient to the lowly tasks of evaluation and description demanded by the condition of everyday extremity and the eugenic answers to its manifold problems. More than merely technological change makes what was hitherto invisible not only visible but decisive.

Nuclear magnetic resonance spectroscopy (NMR/MRI), positron emission tomography (PET) and several other parallel innovations in multidimensional body imaging have remade the relationship between the seeable and the unseen. By imaging the body in new ways, they impact upon the ways that embodied humanity is imagined and upon the status of bio-racial differences that vanish at these levels of resolution. Whether it is the IBM logo being spelled out in individual atoms of xenon or the non-specific dream of gaining control over the big world 'by fiddling with the nanoscale entities of which it is composed', the movement is always in one direction: downwards and inwards. Our question should

be this: where do these changes leave racial difference, particularly where it cannot readily be correlated with simple genetic variation?

Michel Foucault, whose early work explored useful historical precedents for the contemporary shift towards this nanoscale is an inspiring but frustrating guide to these problems. From my standpoint, he seems to have been insufficiently attuned to the significance of protracted struggles over the unity of mankind that attended the emergence of biopolitics and appears to have been disinterested in the meaning of specifically racial-logical differences in the context of anthropology's presentation of the species as a unified object of knowledge and power. To put it simply, though he identified man as both the pivot and the product of the new relationship between words and things, he moved too swiftly towards a sense of modern humanity unified in its immiserating passage from sanguinity to sexuality. He, too, failed to appreciate how the fervent belief that Africans and their new world descendants were less than human, might have affected this transformation and its epistemic correlates. Perhaps he was not haunted, as I think we still should be, by the famous image of an orangutan carrying off a Negro girl that comprised the frontispiece of Linnaeus' *A Genuine and Universal System of Natural History*. The central, inescapable problem presented in that picture is the suggested kinship between these sub- and anti-human species rather than the fact that their conflictual interrelation is figured through the idea of rape. The picture's historic setting and the interpretative puzzle presents point to the unresolved issue of how 'race' interrelates with sex, gender and sexuality; something that is further than ever from being settled and which focuses a new and urgent agenda for future work. The picture and its relation to that foundational text raise other uncomfortable matters: the characteristics of the new, post-Vesalian semiotics of the body and the relationship between text and image in the performative constitution of 'races' were not one in which words were simply, automatically or consistently able to dominate images – icons – that went far beyond any merely illustrative function.

The extensive debate as to whether Negroes should be accorded membership of the family of mankind (a group whose particularity was inaugurated, proved, produced and celebrated by the transformed relationship between words and things that crystallized at the end of the eighteenth century) was more central to the formation and reproduction of the modern episteme than Foucault appreciated. I raise this, not to pillory him, nor to reopen discussion of how that process has been reconstructed by historians of science, but rather because his study of that fateful change is an important resource in our own situation where similar processes are observable.

One intermediate example may help to make the argument about scale less abstract. Let me propose that the dismal order of power and differentiation – defined by its intention to make the mute body disclose the truth of its racial identities – can be apprehended through the critical notion of 'epidermalization' bequeathed to us by Frantz Fanon. That idea was born from a philosopher-psychologist's phenomenological ambitions and their distinctive way of seeing, as well as understanding, the importance of sight. It refers to a historically specific system for making bodies meaningful by endowing in them qualities of 'colour'. But the term has a wider applicability than its recent colonial origins would suggest. Emmanuel Chukwudi Eze and Christian M. Neugebauer have reminded us recently that Kant's *Physische Geographie* said more than his contemporary celebrants like to admit about the qualities of Negro skin and the practical problems it presented when pain had to be inflicted with a split bamboo cane. Like Hegel's better known opinions on the Negro and the limitations he placed upon the African's capacity for historical

action, these sentiments can be thought of as exemplifying epidermal thinking in its emergent form.

In an era where colonial power had made epidermalizing into a dominant principle of political power, Dr. Fanon used the idea of indexing the estrangement from authentic human being in the body and being in the world that colonial social relations had wrought. Epidermalized power violated the human body in its symmetrical, intersubjective, social humanity, in its species being, in its fragile relationship to other fragile bodies and in its connection to the redemptive potential inherent in its own wholesome or perhaps its suffering corporeality, our being towards death. Fanon's notion supplies an interesting footnote to the whole history of racial sciences and the exclusive notions of colour-coded humanity that they specified. We need to find its contemporary analogs not where he looked, on the surface of the body, but deep within it. Their pursuit may yet yield the anti-toxins capable of silencing raciology forever.